

MONGOLIA

At the time of the Mongol Empire's invasion of China in the 13th century, the Mongols drank a tea called "suutei tsai," a strong, milky tea made with pressed black tea, water, milk, salt, and, occasionally, fried millet. During their time in China, the Mongols rejected Chinese tea culture in favor of their traditional salty black tea.

Tea supplemented the Mongol diet, which mostly consisted of dairy, meat, and grains. As water was scarce and, therefore, sacred to the Mongols, they did not drink it on its own, but used it to make their suutei tsai. Milk from the family's herd of cows, yaks, goats, mares, sheep, or camels was boiled together with tea, water, and salt, then ladled from a height into tea bowls.

Suutei tsai is still an essential part of Mongolian society. The tea is consumed frequently during the day and at various occasions, such as to seal business deals, welcome guests, or at family gatherings. It is considered rude to refuse an offer of suutei tsai.

TIBET

Tibet's association with tea can be traced back to the 13th century, when the Chinese traded tea for Tibetan horses along the famous Tea Horse Road. This treacherous network of caravan trails and mountain

footpaths linked the Sichuan province in southwest China to Tibet. Although most of Tibet does not have the right terroir for growing tea, farmers in the region of Pemagul grow a small amount that is made into black brick tea. Tibetans still use this tea, little known and not widely available outside of Tibet, to make their distinctive yak butter tea, known as po cha.

Po cha is made by boiling a large amount of crushed brick tea in hot water for half a day to make a strong tea liquor. This tea liquor, along with yak milk, butter, and salt, is then poured into a dogmo, a long wooden churn, and churned and beaten until it is creamy, rich, and light in color. The po cha is poured into a teapot, traditionally made of metal but now commonly made of ceramics, and then into large wooden or earthenware cups for drinking. It is customary for the drinker to sip the tea leisurely, allowing the host to top up the cup after every sip. While the salty po cha can be an acquired taste for visitors, Tibetans rely on the rich tea to provide them with the additional calories required to survive in the region's harsh climate and high elevations. Tibetan nomads are said to drink up to 40 cups of po cha a day.

IT IS USUAL
FOR EAST
FRISIANS TO
DRINK THREE
CUPS OF TEA
PER SITTING



PO CHA

This salty yak butter tea from Tibet is also enjoyed in Nepal, Bhutan, and the Himalayan regions of India.